

# GLOSSARY OF TERMS

*Terms printed in italics refer to other glossary entries.*

**Acidic** [of soil]. With a *pH* value of less than 7; see also *alkaline* and *neutral*.

**Adventitious** [of roots]. Arising directly from a stem or leaf.

**Aerial root.** See *root*.

**Air-layering.** A method of propagation by which a portion of stem is induced to root by enclosing it in a suitable medium, such as damp moss, and securing it with plastic sheeting; roots will form if the moss is kept moist.

**Alkaline** [of soil]. With a *pH* value of more than 7; some plants will not tolerate alkaline soils and must be grown in *neutral* or *acidic* soil.

**Alpine house.** An unheated greenhouse, used for the cultivation of mainly alpine and bulbous plants, that provides greater ventilation and usually more light than a conventional greenhouse.

**Alternate** [of leaves]. Borne singly at each *node*, on either side of a stem.

**Annual.** A plant that completes its life cycle, from germination through to flowering and seeding and then death, in one growing season.

**Anther.** The part of a stamen that produces pollen; it is usually borne on a filament.

**Apex.** The tip or growing point of an organ such as a leaf or shoot.

**Areole.** A modified, cushionlike *tubercle*, peculiar to the family Cactaceae, that bears hairs, spines, leaves, side-branches or flowers.

**Asclepiad.** A member of the family Asclepiadaceae, e.g. *Asclepias*, *Hoya*, *Stephanotis*.

**Auricle.** An earlike lobe such as is sometimes found at the base of a leaf.

**Awn.** A stiff, bristlelike projection commonly found on grass seeds and *spikelets*.

**Axil.** The angle between a leaf and stem where an axillary bud develops.

**Bedding plant.** A plant that is mass-planted to provide a temporary display.

**Biennial.** A plant that flowers, seeds, and dies in the second season after germination, producing only stems, roots, and leaves in the first season.

**Blade.** The flattened and often broad part of a leaf.

**Bloom.** 1. A flower or blossom. 2. A fine, waxy, whitish or bluish-white coating on stems, leaves or fruits.

**Bog garden.** An area where the soil is kept permanently damp but not waterlogged.

**Bole.** The trunk of a tree from ground level to the first major branch.

**Bolt.** To produce flowers and seed prematurely, particularly in the case of vegetables such as lettuce and beetroot.

**Bonsai.** A method of producing dwarf trees or shrubs by special techniques that include pruning roots, pinching out shoots, removing growth buds, and training branches and stems.

**Bract.** A modified leaf at the base of a flower or flower cluster. Bracts may resemble normal leaves or be reduced

and scalelike in appearance; they are often large and brightly colored.

**Bud.** A rudimentary or condensed shoot containing embryonic leaves or flowers.

**Bulb.** A storage organ consisting mainly of fleshy scales and swollen, modified leaf-bases on a much reduced stem. Bulbs usually, but not always, grow underground.

**Bulbil.** A small, *bulb*-like organ, often borne in a leaf *axil*, occasionally in a *flower head*; it may be used for propagation.

**Bulblet.** A small *bulb* produced at the base of a mature one.

**Bur.** 1. A prickly or spiny *fruit*, or aggregate of fruits. 2. A woody outgrowth on the stems of certain trees.

**Cactus** (pl. cacti). A member of the family Cactaceae, often *succulent* and spiny.

**Calyx** (pl. calyces). The outer part of a flower, usually small and green but sometimes showy and brightly colored, that encloses the petals in bud and is formed from the *sepals*.

**Capsule.** A dry *fruit* that splits open when ripe to release its seeds.

**Carpel.** The female portion of a flower, or part of it, consisting of an *ovary*, *stigma*, and *style*.

**Catkin.** A flower cluster, normally pendulous. Flowers lack petals, are often stalkless, surrounded by scalelike *bracts*, and are usually unisexual.

**Caudex** (pl. caudices). The stem base of a woody plant such as a *palm* or tree fern.

**Cladode.** A stem, often flattened, with the function and appearance of a leaf.

**Claw.** The narrow, basal portion of petals in some genera, e.g. *Dianthus*.

**Climber.** A plant that climbs using other plants or objects as a support: a **leaf-stalk** climber by coiling its leaf stalks around supports; a **root** climber by producing aerial, supporting roots; a **self-clinging** climber by means of suckering pads; a **tendrill** climber by coiling its tendrils; a **twining** climber by coiling stems. **Scandent**, **scrambling**, and **trailing climbers** produce long stems that grow over plants or other supports; they attach themselves only loosely, if at all.

**Clone.** A group of genetically identical plants, propagated vegetatively.

**Compound.** Made up of several or many parts, e.g. a leaf divided into 2 or more *leaflets*.

**Cone.** The clustered flowers or woody, seed-bearing structures of a conifer.

**Coppice.** To cut back to near ground level each year in order to produce vigorous, ornamental shoots, as is usual with some *Cornus* and *Eucalyptus*.

**Cordon.** A trained plant restricted in growth to one main stem, occasionally 2–4 stems.

**Corm.** A *bulb*-like, underground storage organ consisting mainly of a swollen stem base and often surrounded by a papery tunic.

**Cormlet.** A small *corm* arising at the base of a mature one.

**Corolla.** The part of a flower formed by the petals.

**Corona** (crown). A petallike outgrowth sometimes borne on the *corolla*, e.g. the trumpet or cup of a *Narcissus*.

**Corymb.** A racemose flower cluster in which the inner flower stalks are shorter than the outer, resulting in a rounded or flat-topped head.

**Cotyledon.** See *seed leaf*.

**Creeper.** A plant that grows close to the ground, usually rooting as it spreads.

**Crisped.** Minutely wavy-edged.

**Crown.** 1. The part of the plant at or just below the soil surface from which new shoots are produced and to which they die back in fall. 2. The upper, branched part of a tree above the *bole*. 3. A *corona*.

**Culm.** The usually hollow stem of a grass or bamboo.

**Cutting.** A section of a plant that is removed and used for propagation. The various types of cutting are: **basal**—taken from the base of a plant (usually herbaceous) as it begins to produce growth in spring; **greenwood**—made from the tip of young growth; **hardwood**—mature wood taken at the end of the growing season; **leaf**—a detached leaf or part of a leaf; **root**—part of a semimature or mature root; **semiripe**—half-ripened wood taken during the growing season; softwood— young growth taken at the beginning of the growing season; **stem**—a greenwood, hardwood, semiripe or softwood cutting; **tip**—a greenwood cutting.

**Cyme.** A flower cluster in which each growing point terminates in a flower.

**Deadhead.** To remove spent flower heads so as to promote further growth or flowering, prevent seeding, or improve appearance.

**Deciduous.** Losing its leaves annually at the end of the growing season; **semi-deciduous** plants lose only some leaves.

**Decumbent.** Growing close to the ground but ascending at the tips.

**Dentate.** With toothed margins.

**Die-back.** Death of the tips of shoots due to frost or disease.

**Dioecious.** Bearing male and female flowers on separate plants.

**Disbud.** To remove surplus buds to promote larger flowers or fruits.

**Disk floret, disk flower.** A small and often inconspicuous, usually tubular flower, one of many that comprise the central portion of a composite flower head such as a daisy.

**Division.** A method of propagation by which a clump is divided into several parts during dormancy.

**Elliptic** [of leaves]. Broadening in the center and narrowing toward each end.

**Entire** [of leaves]. With untoothed margins.

**Epiphyte.** A plant that grows on the surface of another without being parasitic.

**Evergreen.** Retaining its leaves at the end of the growing season, although losing some older leaves regularly throughout the year; **semievergreen** plants retain only some leaves or lose older leaves only when the new growth is produced.

**F1 hybrid.** The first generation derived from crossing 2 distinct plants, usually when the parents are purebred lines and the offspring are vigorous. Seed from F1 hybrids does not come *true* to type.

**Fall.** An outer *perianth segment* of an iris, which projects outward or downward from the inner segments.

**Fan palm.** A *palm* with *palmate* rather than *pinnate* leaves.

**Farina.** A powdery, white, sometimes yellowish deposit naturally occurring on some leaves and flowers.

**Fibrous root.** A fine, young root, usually one of many.

**Filament.** The stalk of an *anther*.

**Floret.** A single flower in a head of many flowers.

**Flower.** The basic flower forms are: **single**, with one row of usually 4–6 petals; **semidouble**, with more petals, usually in 2 rows; **double**, with many petals in several rows and few or no stamens; **fully double**, usually rounded in shape, with densely packed petals and the stamens absent or obscured.

**Flower head.** A mass of small *flowers* or *florets* that together appear as one flower, e.g. a daisy.

**Force.** To induce artificially the early production of growth, flowers or *fruits*.

**Frond.** The leaflike organ of a fern. Some ferns produce both barren and fertile fronds, the fertile fronds bearing *spores*.

**Fruit.** The structure in plants that bears one or more ripe seeds, e.g. a berry or nut.

**Glabrous.** Not hairy.

**Glaucous.** Bluish-white, bluish-green or bluish-gray.

**Globose.** Spherical.

**Glochid.** One of the barbed bristles or hairs borne on a cactus *areole*.

**Grafting.** A method of propagation by which an artificial union is made between different parts of individual plants; usually the *shoot* (scion) of one is grafted onto the *rootstock* (stock) of another.

**Heel.** The small portion of old wood that is retained at the base of a cutting when it is removed from the stem.

**Herbaceous.** Dying down at the end of the growing season.

**Hose-in-hose** [of flowers]. With one *corolla* borne inside another, forming a double or semidouble *flower*.

**Imbricated.** Overlapping, like roof tiles.

**Inflorescence.** A cluster of flowers with a distinct arrangement, e.g. *corymb*, *cyme*, *panicle*, *raceme*, *spike*, *umbel*.

**Insectivorous plant.** A plant that traps and digests insects and other small animals to supplement its nutrient intake.

**Key.** A winged seed like those produced by the sycamore (*Acer pseudoplatanus*).

**Lateral.** A side growth that arises from the side of a shoot or root.

**Layering.** A method of propagation by which a stem is induced to root by being pegged down into the soil while it is still attached to the parent plant. See also *air-layering*.

**Leaflet.** A subdivision of a compound leaf.

**Lenticel.** A small, usually corky area on a stem or other part of a plant, which acts as a breathing pore.

**Lime.** Compounds of calcium; the amount of lime in soil determines whether it is *alkaline*, *neutral*, or *acidic*.

**Linear** [of leaves]. Very narrow with parallel sides.

**Lip.** A lobe comprising 2 or more flat or sometimes pouched *perianth segments*.